

ANI

Pawar for alleged money-laundering in the Maharashtra State Cooperative Bank (MSCB) case, he turned that into political capital by taking an aggressive stand and threatening to visit the agency's office in connection with the probe. This led to the ED backing off and sympathy for Pawar in rural Maharashtra and among voters of the dominant Maratha community, where he has a base. Later, when the victory of the BJP-Shiv Sena alliance in the state assembly polls seemed a foregone conclusion, Pawar, then 79 and a cancer survivor, led a spirited fightback, even addressing a public meeting in pouring rain at Satara.

"As long as he is in good health, Pawar will never step down from a leadership role...Ajit is being isolated gradually. Eventually, Pawar may withdraw his resignation or choose Sule as his successor. If he emerges stronger from this episode, he may eventually even replace Ajit as the leader of Opposition with a confidante like Jayant Patil," a Congress leader explains. "The ambitions of Ajit and his team were becoming a problem for Pawar... even a team player gets upset when he has no unconditional support from the party," says another Congress leader. He feels that Sule could even be chosen as the NCP national working president.

Senior leaders of the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) too have thoughts on the same lines. "*Pawar khunta halwun balkat kartahet* (Pawar is shaking the nail to embed it deeper)," says one of them, using a phrase many leaders have used to describe Pawar's moves.

Senior journalist Nikhil Wagle describes the move as a "Pawar googly for Ajit...such shock therapies are part of his politics". Wagle feels that Pawar could be aiming at installing Sule as his successor while controlling the party from behind the scenes. The question is, will Ajit accept this? ■

DEADLY BUSINESS

By Amitabh Srivastava

On March 16, shortly after 13-year-old Tushar, a Class 6 student, went missing from his house in Patna's Kanhauli village, his father, Raj Kishore Pandit, received a ransom call on WhatsApp. The kidnapper wanted Pandit, a government schoolteacher, to pay up Rs 40 lakh for the safe return of his son. Three days later, police recovered the boy's charred body from a secluded spot and arrested the alleged perpetrator—Mukesh Pandey, 28, who ran a coaching centre and private school in the same locality.

Police claim Pandey, con-

EXORBITANT INTEREST RATES CHARGED BY ILLEGAL LENDERS ARE DRIVING BORROWERS TO DESPAIR AND CRIME IN BIHAR

fronted by private moneylenders from whom he had borrowed Rs 20 lakh, found an easy target in his former student Tushar, who unsuspectingly accompanied the accused only to be strangled to death, his body later burnt to hide evidence. Pandey then allegedly started sending ransom messages to Pandit using Tushar's phone. When nabbed on March 19, say police, he was still carrying his victim's phone.

The vicious circle of debt owing to exorbitant interest rates charged by private moneylenders in Bihar (at times as high as 10 per cent per month) has often brought out the worst in the bor-